

Hospital Discharge Equipment Guide for Caregivers

A calm, step-by-step guide for getting equipment and your home ready when someone is coming home from the hospital.

For caregivers, family members, and friends.

When someone you care about is about to leave the hospital, there is often very little time. This guide helps you slow things down enough to ask the right questions, get your home ready, and find the equipment you need. You do not have to do everything at once, and you do not have to do it alone.

1. What to ask the care team before discharge day

Ask the nurse, case manager, social worker, or therapist. Write the answers down, or bring someone to take notes.

- ☐ What equipment will be needed at home on the first day, and what can wait?
- ☐ Who orders it? Will the hospital, a home health company, or a dealer provide it?
- ☐ When and where will it be delivered? Will someone show us how to use it?
- ☐ What may insurance cover, and what do we need to pay for? Who can check this for us? Coverage rules differ, so ask the plan.
- ☐ How long is the equipment likely to be needed? Days, weeks, or longer?
- ☐ Can a therapist visit the home, or look at photos of the home, to suggest what will work?
- ☐ Who do we call if the equipment breaks, or if something does not feel right?

2. Rent, buy new, or buy used

There is no single right answer. Here is how people often think about it.

- **Renting** often makes sense when the need is short, or when you do not yet know what you will need. Ask what the rental includes, such as delivery, setup, repairs, and pick-up, and what it costs per month.
- **Buying new** may make sense for items that are used every day for a long time, or when you want a warranty and a dealer to fit and service it.
- **Buying used** often costs much less, and can be a good choice for items such as walkers, wheelchairs, shower chairs, and lift chairs. Look carefully, test everything, and consider asking a dealer or therapist to check it first. Used items usually have no warranty.
- **Borrowing** from a loan closet or a community group costs little or nothing, and is worth asking about first.

Ask the care team before you buy. Some items may need a prescription or a specific size to be covered by insurance.

3. Home readiness checklist

Walk through the home with a tape measure, and with someone who will help. Fix the easy things first.

Entrances and steps

- ☐ How many steps are at each entrance? Is there a railing on both sides?
- ☐ Is there a step-free way in? If not, is a ramp possible, now or later?
- ☐ Is the entrance well lit, and are walkways clear of ice, leaves, and clutter?

Doorways and hallways

- ☐ Measure every doorway the person will use. Walkers and wheelchairs need room to turn.
- ☐ Move furniture to make a clear, wide path.

Bathroom

- ☐ Measure the doorway and the room. Is there room for a shower chair, a raised toilet seat, or a commode?
- ☐ Is there a non-slip mat, and are grab bars installed in the wall studs by a professional?

Bedroom

- ☐ Will the bed be easy to get in and out of? Ask the therapist if a bed rail, a higher bed, or a hospital bed is needed.
- ☐ Is there a light and a phone within reach of the bed?

Kitchen and living areas

- ☐ Move everyday items, such as medicines, glasses, and food, to waist and shoulder height.
- ☐ Choose a comfortable, firm chair with arms.

Floors, lighting, and clutter

- ☐ Remove throw rugs and loose cords.
- ☐ Add night lights in the bedroom, hallway, and bathroom.
- ☐ Clear stairs and landings of anything that could trip someone.

4. Common equipment, explained simply

Use this as a conversation starter with the therapist. They can tell you what fits and how to use it.

Walkers and rollators

These give support while standing and walking. A walker has no wheels or two wheels. A rollator has wheels, hand brakes, and often a seat. Ask: Which type fits the person's balance? How high should the handles be? Do we need a seat?

Wheelchairs

These are for people who cannot walk far or safely. Manual chairs are pushed by the user or a helper. Power chairs and scooters are driven with a battery. Ask: What size and type, and what weight limit? Who should fit the chair? Will it fit our doors and car?

Transfer aids

Transfer boards, belts, and poles help someone move from bed to chair, or chair to car. Ask the therapist to show you how to use these. Using them wrongly can cause injury.

Shower chairs and benches

These let someone sit while bathing. Ask: Does the person need a back, arms, or a hand-held shower? What height is safest for getting in and out?

Raised toilet seats and commodes

These make it easier to sit and stand. A commode can sit by the bed. Ask: What height should it be? Do we need arms?

Lift chairs

A lift chair tilts forward to help someone stand. Ask: How much help does the person need to stand? What size chair fits? Does it have a backup battery for power outages?

Hospital beds

These adjust the head, feet, and height. Ask: Does the person need rails? What mattress type? Where in the home will it fit, and who will set it up?

Ramps

Ramps replace steps. Ask a dealer or a professional to measure for the right length and slope. A ramp that is too steep can be dangerous.

5. Getting equipment fast when time is short

- **A local dealer** can often deliver, set up, and show you how to use equipment. Call early. Ask what is in stock.

- **A loan closet**, a church group, or a senior services office may lend equipment at no cost. Ask the hospital social worker who to call.
- **A used marketplace** such as Mobility Database may have what you need nearby, often at a lower price. Use the grades and the seller checklist, ask questions, and test the item if you can. In Wisconsin you can also request delivery.
- **Ask friends and neighbors.** People often have a walker or shower chair in a closet and are glad to pass it on.

If you buy used, plan to clean it well, and ask a therapist or dealer to check the fit.

6. Caregiver safety

- ☐ Ask a therapist to show you how to help someone stand, sit, and move safely. Practice with them watching.
- ☐ Do not lift more than you safely can. Use equipment, and ask for help from another person when needed.
- ☐ Wear shoes with grip, and keep walkways clear.
- ☐ Ask about home health aides, a visiting nurse, or respite care, and about community services for seniors. These can give you rest and reduce risk.
- ☐ If a fall happens, or you are unsure what to do, call the person's doctor. In an emergency, call 911.

7. Questions to ask sheet (bring this to the hospital)

Question	Answer and who told me
What equipment do we need on day one?	
Who is ordering it, and when will it arrive?	
Who will show us how to use it?	
What may insurance cover? Who can check?	
How long will we need it?	
Can a therapist visit or look at photos of the home?	
What home changes are most important?	
Who do we call after hours if something breaks?	
What help is available for the caregiver?	
Phone numbers to keep	

8. My equipment log

Keep a simple record. It helps when you need service, return a rental, or pass the item along later.

Item	Source (rented, bought, borrowed)	Date	Serial number	Service notes

9. Take care of yourself too

Caring for someone is real work, and it can be tiring. You are allowed to ask for help, to say no to some things, and to take a break. Ask a friend to take a shift. Ask the social worker about caregiver support. Sleep, eat, and see a doctor yourself. You will be a better helper when you are looked after too.

When the equipment is no longer needed, you can pass it on to someone else by listing it, or donating it, through Mobility Database.

Please read.

This guide is general information to help you ask good questions. It is not medical, legal, tax, or insurance advice, and it does not guarantee that any piece of equipment is safe or right for any person. Ask a doctor, occupational therapist, physical therapist, or qualified equipment dealer about fit, safety, and use. Prices, coverage rules, and recall information change, so check current sources. Mobility Database is a listing service and does not inspect, sell, or guarantee equipment.

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